

FROM THE EDITORS Welcome to the October 2024 edition of Voice Express. Our correspondents bring you the stories that matter — from frontlines of policy to quiet revolutions in culture and science.

LABOUR

## “Companies Have Made Up Their Own Law”: Labour Unions, Activists Host PC Ahead of Maruti Suzuki Workers’ ‘Chalo IMT’ March on Friday, Implore Public to Join

At the Press Club of India on 16th October 2024, representatives of four major ignored workers' struggles — Maruti-Suzuki, Samsung India, Dolphin-Lucas TVS, and Darjeeling's tea plantation workers — held a press conference to address the near-total absence of media coverage of their movements, ahead of the 'Chalo IMT' march.

BY MOULI SHARMA



The conference at the Press Club of India held on the 16th of October, paneled spokespersons of the many prominent workers’ protests across the country that have been absent from the mainstream media, & implored the public & press to acknowledge their struggle. Senior Supreme Court Adv. Colin Gonsalves and Anjali Deshpande, the latter being one of the few journalists to cover the Maruti Workers’ struggle when it began over a decade ago, were also present.

16th October 2024, New Delhi: On Wednesday afternoon at the Press Club of India, representatives from four of the country’s ongoing workers’ protests along with prominent journalists & activists organized a press conference to address the stark lack of media attention these movements are receiving in the mainstream news. The four movements in question are the Maruti Suzuki workers’ struggle in Manesar, Haryana; the Samsung strike in Sriperumbudur, Tamil Nadu; the Dolphin and Lucas TVS struggle in Uttarakhand; and the Darjeeling hills tea plantation workers’ struggle in West Bengal. Of these, only the Samsung strike in Tamil Nadu has featured in the mainstream news, largely owing to the workers’ own effort to carry out independent reporting.

**Maruti Suzuki Workers Struggle, Manesar, Haryana: "Chalo IMT Manesar!"**

On 18th July 2012, after an incident of caste-based discrimination between management & the then recently formed union spiraled out of control, 13 workers in Maruti’s Manesar factory were charged with crimes they did not commit, arrested & jailed for sentences of life. This is the incident that sparked the movement that spanned 10 years and 3 plants of Maruti Suzuki, resulting in the illegal termination of 2346 workers, the arrest of as many as 150 workers, & withheld dues of over 20,000. In 2017, 117 of the detained workers were acquitted and released, after wrongfully being jailed for several years. The continued resistance of the Maruti workers – most of whom despite being acquitted carry with them the tag of ‘jailed worker’ & cannot find employment - has been a testament to their resilience, & their unceasing decade-long struggle finally resulted in the 13 jailed for life leaders securing bail in 2022.

Despite the dramatics of their story, media coverage of this 12-year-long battle has been negligible. A month ago, prior to the Haryana elections, the workers resumed their strike through an indefinite st-in starting on the 18th of September. This was covered by Scroll.in, but the piece itself was notably written by none other than Nandita Haksar, who is the co-author of Anjali Deshpande in their book, “Japanese Management, Indian Resistance,” one of the only pieces of long-form journalistic coverage the case. The latter was also one of the speakers at the press conference.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 2 →

THE VOICE EXPRESS

OCTOBER 2024

Labour activist & member of the Maruti Suzuki Struggle Committee, Satish, could be seen getting emotional at the press conference, recounting the police torture meted out to protesting workers back in 2012-2014.

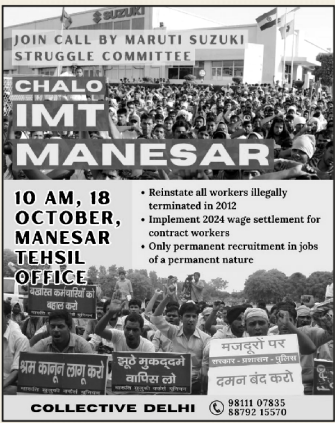


From left to right: Labour Activist Nayanjyoti, Union Member Ajit, Labour Activist Santosh, Union Member Satish, Sen. SC Adv. Colin Gonsalves & Journalist Anjali Deshpande, 16th October 2024 at the Press Club of India. Source: TVE

“They were picking us off one by one. Finally, we gathered everyone in the village & union & showed up in front of the police together saying, ‘You arrest one of us each day, beat him up, torture him. We thought we’d gather in one place to make it easy for you, so you can just arrest all of us now.’ That is how the arrests stopped,” Satish said.

In her book, Anjali Deshpande points to a small, seemingly insignificant figure to tell the reader what the average day for a worker in Maruti’s factory would be like: 7.5 minutes. This is the amount of time a worker was given in the factory to do everything he needed to do, twice in the entire day’s shift. “The tea itself took 1.5 minutes to arrive. So they had to choose between having a cup of tea or taking a leak. Soon, they learned to do both at the same time,” says a passage from the book, read out at the conference by Santosh. "It is impossible for us middle-class people to even imagine the desperation of these 7.5 minutes, let alone understand the ground reality of auto sector workers," said Deshpande.

After the polls, whatever hope the workers had put in politics stands quashed. Since 10th October 2024, the workers have instead doubled down on their fight against Maruti, supplementing their infinite sit-in with a relay hunger strike. Their demands are simple: immediate reinstatement of all illegally terminated workers (2346 including both permanent & contract workers), proper wage settlement & permanency for all temporary workers (more than 20,00 in total), and the scrapping of all false cases slapped against Maruti workers over the years without evidence or due procedure. On Friday, the workers will march to IMT Manesar, & urge the press & citizenry to join them at the Manesar Tehsil Office.



Source: COLLECTIVE

### Dolphin and Lucas TVS Struggle in Rudrapur, Uttarakhand: Women Workers Stalked, Harassed for Protesting

“In April 2023, the Uttarakhand government revised the minimum wage for factory workers, which they announced a little later. When the Dolphin workers’ struggle was born, it was born because of this revised minimum wage. This was their demand, which is the basic, fundamental demand of any factory worker anywhere. Even the government & the Supreme Court’s own laws guarantee this much: the bare minimum criteria without which you are no more than bonded labour. There were mostly women working in the factory at the time, & you’ll be shocked to hear this, but this ‘minimum wage’ of theirs was just 5,000 rupees a month. They worked 8 hours a day for a wage of 5,000 rupees,” Labour representative & Bellsonica auto employee union member Ajit’s statement lists the blatant violations of various legislations that these women had to face, including violations of the Payment of Bonus Act, 1965; the Factories Act, 1948; & the Minimum Wages Act, 1948.

As a result of the protests, 48 permanent workers have been terminated without notice and around 4,000 permanent workers (as per the release) have been shifted to contractual status in 5 plants of Dolphin, an auto component supplier to Maruti & other companies.

*“Shifting permanent workers to contract allows the company to subvert the Minimum Wage Act, such that now the ‘contract workers’ have to work overtime to earn the 5,000 rupees of minimum wage, Women who were working 8 hours a day had to now work 12 hours a day just to get Rs. 5000 a month. This is why they shifted over 3,000 workers’ status from permanent to contractual. This is a blatant violation of the most basic legal provisions. These companies have made up their own law.” —Ajit, Bellsonica Auto Comonent Employees Union, 16th October 2024, PCI*

Ajit’s statement also recounts the details of the physical & legal intimidation that the protesting workers had to face, with several women being stalked, harassed & called slurs by private bouncers hired to barricade their protests. A protestor’s skull was cracked open. When they went to the police to report these incidents, cases were instead registered against them.

"The workers started their infinite dharnas from (sic) 28th August 2024 demanding permanent jobs and reinstatement with full back wages. Luas TVS workers [have been struggling] for nearly one year & are continuing their dharna since 26th October 2024,” as per the release, with similar demands along with the recognition of their union.

In addition, since the last Thursday, a Mazdoor-Kisan Mahapanchayat in Rudrapur, in the industrial area of Udham Singh Nagar, workers of Dolphin, Lucas TVS, Interarch & Karolia Lighting have come together – joined even by outsider unions such as Ajit’s – in an inter-union worker’s struggle that has proved its own capacity for solidarity in the clearest terms possible.



Via Ground Xero

### Darjeeling Hills Tea Plantation Workers’ Struggle in West Bengal: 17 Crores in Unpaid Dues

Earlier in the conference, activist Nayanjyoti spoke of the ongoing Darjeeling hill tea garden worker’s struggle, citing the role of investors in the recent large-scale closures of tea gardens & the massive amounts of unpaid dues, figures that have been so far underreported.

“Owners in the tea plantation business nowadays keep talking a lot about how they’re suffering losses. The business of tea requires certain necessary investments, ones that these ‘speculative [businessmen]’ are not interested in making. Every few years, whole plantations have to be uprooted & replanted, & there are certain annual investments as well that are essential, be it irrigation or any other,” said Nayanjyoti. "Then there is the matter of bonus. When the bonus season comes, i.e. the festive season around August-September, we start seeing garden closures one after another. Basically, when it’s time [to pay the bonus], they simply run away. In the last month alone, there have been talks of multiple gardens closing: Singtom Garden, Peshok, Soom, Lingia, Barnesbeg, Kumai – all of these were up for closure.”

*“When the bonus season comes, i.e. the festive season around August-September, we start seeing garden closures one after another. Basically, when it’s time [to pay the bonus], they simply run away. In the last month alone, there have been talks of multiple gardens closing: Singtom Garden, Peshok, Soom, Lingia, Barnesbeg, Kumai – all of these were up for closure.” —Nayanjyoti, Labour Activist, 16th October 2024, PCI*

Nayanjyoti’s full statement, which went on to discuss not only the 87 plantations in the Kalimpong area but also the additional 227 including the Terai-Dooars regions, all of which in total employ a total of approximately 8 lakh workers, all of whom are being denied their basic rights – from wages to safety equipment – as guaranteed to them under the Plantation Labour Act, 1951. A recent opinion piece by the Darjeeling Chronicle highlighting the struggle of plantation workers cultivating one of the world’s most popular teas makes it clear that the recent workers’ strikes have put the long-ignored exploitation in the industry in the public eye.

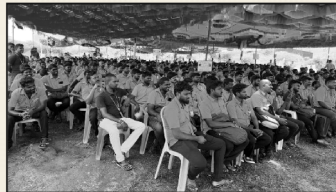


Via Ground Xero

By far the most damning piece of data in the press release as well as Nayanjyoti’s statement, though, was the figure of Rs. 17 crore, which was the total amount of pending wages that the Longview Tea Garden alone owed to its 300 workers up till September 2024, after which their large scale mobilisation resulted in the owners conceding to pay the amount, only part of which has so far been fulfilled.

Beyond this small victory, though, the struggle of the Darjeeling Hills tea gardens is far from over, as they are now in a fierce headlock with the government over rightful rates of bonus & complete fulfillment of pending dues. Recently, BJP’s West Bengal MP Raju Bista has written to the Minister of Commerce & Industry Piyush Goyal & Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee addressing the matter of the closure of ‘at least 10’ tea gardens since 2008, though his suggestions differ from the workers’.

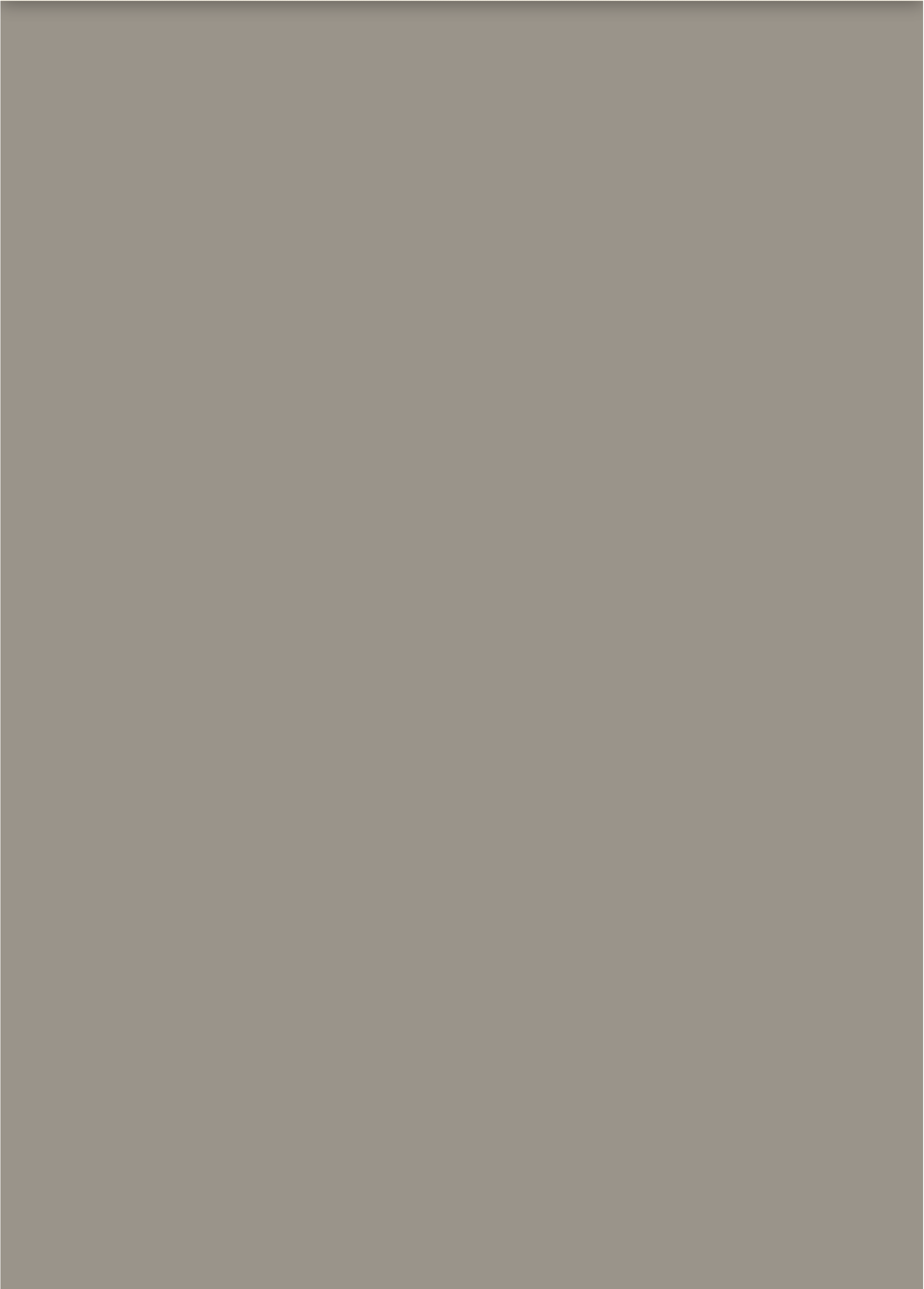
### Samsung Workers’ Strike, Sriperumbudur, Tamil Nadu: A Win for the Workers



Via Ground Xero

“Workers don’t have a canteen or even toilets; these are the things they’re fighting for,” said Mazdoor Patrika’s Santosh, a labour activist & journalist for WorkersUnity – a worker-led media organisation that is trying to fill in the gap of the absent Indian labour beat – representing the Samsung workers in Sriperumbudur. “It was independent organisations that first drew attention to the struggle in Tamil Nadu – Eedena, Ground Xero , & WorkersUnity.”

As per PCI’s official press release, the core issue of the strike is the demand for union recognition. The management refuses to allow a union and claims they have addressed other concerns like better food and transportation, while workers say that these are basic rights that have been neglected for 16 years, and that the strike will continue until the management, “respects the right to unionize & negotiates with the workers’ chosen representatives.” The workers also criticise the government for siding with the company as it blatantly violates labour laws, stating that it seems the government, “only cares about foreign investment.”





As of October 16th, the strike has been called off after workers unanimously voted to end the strike post-progress in government negotiations, a big victory for all labour movements across the nation. The workers will return to work on the 17th, though the right to unionize has yet to gain recognition.

Source: TVE

POLITICS

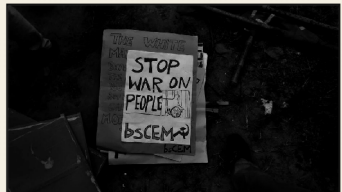
“They Don’t Know How to Kill Me”

G.N. Saibaba — professor, disability rights activist, and political prisoner — spent 3,592 days in the solitary confinement of Nagpur Central Jail under UAPA charges before dying on 12th October 2024. A tribute and an account of the draconian legal machinery used to silence him, written from outside the gates of JNU.

BY KANDARP



The alleged terrorist was handled with appropriate secrecy needed for matters of national security; he was transported discretely to the airport & taken to Nagpur in anti-landmine trucks full of commandos armed with high-tech weaponry, from where more trucks were seen escorting the prisoner to Gadchiroli, where he would be tried 2 . Marathi media quickly reported the big news – a hardcore & dangerous terrorist had been caught, possibly a Maoist leader. This man was DU’s beloved & revered professor, 90% disabled & paralyzed from the waist down since a childhood battle with Polio, Dr. Gokarakonda Naga Saibaba.



Seven months after his release from the Nagpur Central Jail, where he was falsely incarcerated for over 10 years, on the 12th of October 2024, renowned professor & human rights activist Dr. G. N. Saibaba passed away. The next evening, a small group of people at JNU’s iconic Sabarmati Dhaba came together to do something enthusiasm cannot help with – grieve. Photojournalist Kandarp Bhargav’s photographs document the necropolitics of not just a disabled academic’s institutional murder , but also those of another, quieter one still in progress. It is the murder of the academic apparatus of this country, one which in these photographs is being asked to organize & attend its own wake.



On the banners behind the tennis court where the crowd eventually gathered & in the WhatsApp forward stragglers who’d made up their minds last minute were toting around, the names given to the gathering varied. The big red banner nestled between the communist flags on the hedges called it the ‘Red Salute to Comrade G. N. Saibaba.’ The forward doing the rounds on people’s statuses called it a ‘Public Meeting’ remembering his legacy. The posters lined on a string stretched across the court read like a protest against the law, but the voices in the crowd sounded hesitant the way they rarely are at those, like they’re undecided which of the three they want this to be. Hindu’s article the next morning about the event conveniently labeled it a ‘tribute by friends, professors & students,’ which sounds - if nothing else - nice.

“The event in itself was in solidarity with G.N Saibaba and yet was a protest against the oppression of the authorities and the government. The meeting started with loud hails of anti-fascist sloganeering [which gave the idea of it being a protest]. Eventually, several people gave speeches,” Kandarp says, trying to describe the atmosphere of the meeting.

Perhaps, the first stage of grief has always been confusion.



Three days before Saibaba’s death from a postoperative complication in a gallbladder surgery, industrialist & chairperson of the multibillion-dollar Tata conglomerate, Ratan N. Tata passed away due to natural causes at the age of 86. People the world over being platformed by national & global media, particularly the government & laypeople of Maharashtra, alongside social media users all across the globe were heartbroken over his death, with celebrities & politicians flocking either to X (formerly Twitter) or to his state-sponsored last rites in Mumbai to pay him their last respects. G. N. Saibaba’s history with Maharashtra & the State is just as rich as Tata’s 3 , but not quite as wholesome. Perhaps that is why the crowd at his makeshift ‘funerals’ like the one at JNU – or the ‘ real one ’ in Hyderabad – was neither as diverse, as sad, or as newsworthy; nor the queue for it quite as long.



“Ratan Tata was a business person who knew how to deceive struggling low purchasing power people of India, G.N Saibaba [for the government and the masses] was a threat,” says Kandarp, explaining why the sentiments of the masses are more attached to Ratan Tata than activists like Saibaba. “As the state said, ‘Saibaba’s brain is dangerous. His thoughts are dangerous.’ So the mainstream media would never appreciate his struggle and resistance against authoritative oppression.”

His mind worked fine.



When asked who then showed up for the meeting, which was open to all, Kandarp’s answer is unsurprising. “The poster itself mentions all the pro-left student organizations around the campuses of DU and JNU [organizing it],” Kandarp reminds us. “You are limited to your opinion ,” and so is your grief. 4

“The community of people grieving him today are the ones who share comradeship and solidarity in the resistance against the oppression of government institutions – activists and professors from different universities who shared close memories of G.N Saibaba. One of them was Hem Mishra.” This Hem Mishra, of course, is the JNU student who was among the five others jailed alongside Saibaba in the UAPA “Maoist links” case. Like Saibaba, Mishra was also released from jail & acquitted on all charges in March, more than ten years after he was first arrested.

My fellow  
Prisoners,  
Don’t be agonised,  
You’ll get free soon.

Written to Sanjay Kak, from the High-Security Prison cell, Nagpur, to the fellow netizen prisoners of the global virtual space, Dr. G. N. Saibaba, 24 March 2018.

After the meeting at Sabarmati, Mishra would leave for Hyderabad, where Saibaba’s body rested at his brother’s residence before being donated to Telangana’s Gandhi Medical College, to pay his last respects to the man he spent a decade with in hell.

The Mahar was taken to Heaven,  
and the Chamar to Hell.  
Both were entrusted  
with the holy work  
of cleaning the shit of gods  
every morning and evening  
for life and after-life.  
And in the rest of the day,  
they have to only clean the sewage.

Written to Vijay Kumar, based on the stories told by two prisoners who spent prison terms for petty crimes, Dr. G. N. Saibaba, 12th April 2018.

“He would say that one day we would walk out of prison,” Mishra would recall , at the makeshift funeral. “Because we did nothing wrong. We raised our voices against injustice, for the rights of the people, for the rights of Adivasis, Dalits and all the oppressed in this country. We were, and are, fighting for a just cause,” he would say. But Sunday night on the tennis court outside Sabarmati, righteousness did little to soothe anyone’s raw conscience.

A man with silver hair & grandpa glasses stood up against the weight of his shaking cane to remind those who’d come to listen of the legacy his friend left behind, one of endurance & resistance against authoritative oppression. A trade union worker described the distinctive empathy of Saibaba’s politics, so grass-rooted that it would apply directly to the on-ground resistance of the trade union. And when the three long hours of speech & slogan came to a slow, hollow end, it was hardly their pride that stayed with Kandarp on his metro ride home.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 4 →

**“They Don’t Know How to Kill Me”** ·  
CONTINUED FROM PAGE 3



“On my [journey back home], all that hooked me up was the thought of how the government is so afraid of students and such events that they totally record and monitor the spectators and the speakers.” In one of the videos Kandarp took from the meeting, two security guards stand stock still with their hands behind their backs, quietly watching from the boundaries as students chant slogans in memory of Saibaba & his fight against fascism. As the camera hovers over them for more than a second instead of moving past, one of them turns towards it, looking Kandarp in the eye.

Less than a second later, he turns back.



Intimidation & surveillance from campus authorities at protests is far from new phenomena at places like JNU, but Kandarp tells us it is on the rise. “The administration in public universities is restricting any vocal stands from students, be it study circles, meetings, or a protest, and all this has amplified post covid,” he says. “The government is so afraid of students and such events that they totally record and monitor the spectators and the speakers.”



Kandarp also criticizes the NEP for trying to mechanize the education process, conditioning students out of their ability to think critically.

“[They] try to put students in some machine learning structure and want to teach [them] the ideology the center is pleased with: promoting the culture of a certain religion and killing the idea of the secular nation. My experience with professors around Delhi University has been the same.”

Three years ago, after being arrested under the false Bhima Koregaon conspiracy for which several activists were booked & jailed under the same charges that took away 10 years of Hem Mishra & G. N. Saibaba’s lives (‘alleged’ links to Maoist groups under UAPA), 84 year old tribal rights activist, Father Stan Swamy passed away while incarcerated as he was denied bail despite being critically diagnosed with Parkinson’s. The same was done to Saibaba & his fellow prisoners, of whom Pandu Narote succumbed to swine flu in 2022 while also still in jail. It seems that when it comes to the workings of the Indian judicial & extrajudicial apparatus, ideology is not the only thing they intend to kill.

*“You had written, ‘Just like how the state apparatus is sucking the life out of the people and the society, it is squeezing my body dry too. I do not know how much of myself will be left when I leave the prison.’ I too fear the same. Even ablebodied people are not able to endure the harshness of prison life; it must be far worse for you. My biggest concern right now is your health, especially the fact that you have not received any medical treatment in the last four years. Once you wrote to me that you were not sure how long you could survive in these conditions with an abject lack of medical attention. You said that we might hear the news of another Stan Swamy if no treatment is provided to you. Whenever I think of these words, my mind goes to a dark place and a heaviness that does not leave fills my heart.”* —  
January 2022, A.S. Vasantha Kumari, translated from the Telegu by Rajendra Babu Arvini and P. Varalakshmi

As I sat down to edit this photo essay, amidst invitations to DU’s own ‘Public Meeting’ of the same format & subject in the Arts Faculty, Saibaba’s institutional & political haven while he taught English at Ram Lal Anand till his unceremonious & insulting removal from the post in 2021 as a result of the war waged on his character by his own country, I found myself stuck on the image of a lone loudspeaker softly echoing the voices of the attendees’ organized grief. I thought about asking Kandarp if Saibaba’s own voice ever spoke out of that speaker at any point in the meeting, then remembered the circumstance & let it be.



Despite the complete loss of use of his left hand, & near complete loss in his right, G. N. Saibaba would write in prison. Partly for lack of choice; after the state of Maharashtra reinstated jail mulakats post the covid-19 pandemic, all phone calls were stopped. This was only a formal seal on what was already a black box of communication in the form of Nagpur Central Jail, psychologically tormenting prisoners & their families by withholding news of even their medical conditions. But even when his letters had little hope of reaching their intended address, & even though by the end of the decade it would take him 2-3 days to complete a single page of writing because of the deteriorating state of his hand, Saibaba wrote.

He wrote letters to his family, though he was denied even doing that in his mother tongue, & each letter either way had to be arduously translated. He wrote back & forth to his wife, a bastardized memory of their youth where they exchanged pages upon pages of their young, hopeful love. He wrote to the court, afraid for his life in a prison that locked him up like an animal & forced him to beg for life-saving drugs & the dignity of not having to drag himself around by his elbows. He wrote to fictional characters & his students & colleagues to remind them where the real prison was; in our own moral decrepitude. He wrote to his friends.

Through excruciating pain, he never stopped writing. On October 26th 2017, in a letter to his wife, Saibaba wrote a poem remembering the October revolution in Russia a hundred years prior. It is this poem that opens the collection of his writings from prison which came out of it two years before he did, titled, ‘ Why Do You Fear My Way So Much? ’ 6 The title calls on the reader the same, absurd association with Saibaba’s shaking pen that the mainstream media tried to purport 8 years prior when he was first captured: fear.

But Saibaba was never the mastermind they were so intent on having us, asininely, believe. He wrote poetry on art & justice & blades of grass, and remembered the dates in history books. He was an English teacher, till the end, & his only crime was an undying smile & refusing to die when he was asked to.

Infuriated by my undying smile,  
they captured me again.  
I still stubbornly refuse to die.  
The sad thing is that  
they don’t know how to kill me,  
because I love so much  
the sounds of growing grass.

Written to Vasantha,  
remembering the October  
Uprising of 1917, G. N.  
Saibaba, 26th October 2017.



In a pixellated, zoomed-in still from Kandarp’s collection, his lens struggles to get a clean shot of three posters in a line behind the silver-haired speaker’s head. The first of them reads a slightly different version of the line – transformed either in translation or memory: ‘they don’t know how to make me die.’ I mull over the eccentricities of meaning & semantics, & my mind wanders back to the loudspeaker. To the speeches & interviews & papers, to the people and the places, and the book full of prison poetry he’s left behind. As of 12th October 2024, the state certainly figured out how to kill him, the way it killed Stan Swamy & Pandu Narote, & the way it is killing its own academia as we watch it happen. But maybe, it is worth believing, that it will never figure out how to make him die.

#### POLITICS

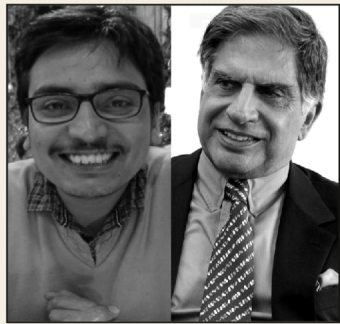
**“Have Spoken Ill of Him in Life, Will Continue to Do So in Death” – Leftist Youth Group Slams ‘Posthumous Veneration’ of Ratan Tata by Foreign & National Press**

As politicians and press commemorated Ratan Tata’s death with state funeral proposals and Bharat Ratna nominations, COLLECTIVE Delhi released a statement refusing to observe the silence demanded by mourning – recounting the Tata Group’s documented history of forceful land acquisition and labour suppression that his philanthropic image was built to obscure.

BY MOULI SHARMA

CONTINUED ON PAGE 5 →





COLLECTIVE Delhi Secretary Sourya’s statement recounts the Tata Group’s long history of forceful land acquisition & human rights violations, calling out the selective memory & revisionist narrative of Tata’s posthumous virtue being put forth by the media in the wake of his death.

As VIPs spent the last 48 hours celebrating the life & mourning the loss of Tata – who died of natural causes on Wednesday morning at the age of 86 – to immense media attention, one side of the coin that has been wholistically ignored by mainstream as well as large parts of independent media is that of the Tata Group’s political history, one that is fraught with violence and controversy. In the cacophony of mournful obituaries & funeral telecasts 2 drowning out any and all counternarratives from the newssphere, one demographic that is sustaining a quiet, consistent voice of dissent, is the youth. Whether through student representatives or through digital apparatuses 3 , the young left has held onto its views on Tata, intent on highlighting the group’s bloody history.

As the country’s press covers which celebrities were seen in attendance of Tata’s (Twitter) funeral, which 23 of his quotes make the best compilation, & writes a headline for every person – from a newspaper vendor 4 to Amitabh Bachchan – that can offer a quote of condolences for the tycoon, young journalists, digital media influencers, & left-wing student organisations in their infancy have been unflinching in their continued critique of the less picturesque aspects of the Tata Group’s evolution. This is the first of a series of articles that hopes to uphold, even if only microscopically, the desperate & delicate balance of news that the Indian press today has seemed to forsake. Here’s charting the other side of the coin.

As in life, so in death.

Left, Right & Centre: Was Tata Beloved By All?

“Today, the 'leftist' Chief Minister of Kerala and a billionaire from Gujarat are both paying tribute to Ratan Tata. It is a matter of great pride for any individual when ideological opponents come together in mourning, but this reflects something deeper.” — Sourya, General Secretary, COLLECTIVE Delhi

This dichotomy, between right, left & Tata, is not an isolated & interesting case study of human multitudes, but something that has remained ever-present throughout the partly fabled tale of the Tata Group’s 200-year 8 tumultuous history. Tata’s institutions & architectures have long defined the murky space of the Indian political centre, having been founded as a business empire that formed the very blueprint of industry in a mixed economy. As India’s economy has shifted away from the part-socialist model to an increasingly capitalist one, the conglomerate’s constitution has similarly evolved. Yet even in 2024, in the steel rods that hold up this country & in the military vehicles that surveil it, the dichotomy survives.

Bastar, Tata Steel, & The ‘Biggest Land Grab Since Columbus’

“On one hand, to ideologically defend their profit-based system, Tata Steel has established institutions like the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS) and Tata Environment Research Institute (TERI) using their financial clout; on the other hand, to pit the oppressed against each other, private militias like Salwa Judum and Operation Green Hunt have been funded by houses like Tata and Jindal.” — Sourya, General Secretary, COLLECTIVE Delhi

“The memorial for 13 martyrs in Kalinga Nagar, Odisha, remains a proud symbol of tribal resistance [against Tata Steel]. When the country’s first ‘Special Economic Zone’ was established in Bengal during the CPI(M) regime in 2003, Tata [was among] its first consumers. In Singur and Nandigram, landless and small farmers were forcibly evicted from their land [by the government for Tata’s Nano plant]. In 2015, when demands for a union arose against falling real wages, union leadership was illegally ousted. [...] Tea plantation workers who grow Tata Tea are now facing the police to unite in

The comparison to Jindal above holds true for Tata in another, even more damning sense. While both groups hide their investment in militant violence & unlawful land acquisition – an ordinary procedure in the industries of steel & power – behind philanthropy & founding educational institutes, the flagship institutions of both groups have come under fire in the past year for controversies relating to censorship of scholars & student groups 15 . While Jindal’s offices issued ‘warnings’ to faculty in the academic sphere for speaking on the escalating violence in Palestine, TISS went as far as formally banning a leftist student organisation, the Progressive Student’s Forum 16 .

“This notice addresses a critical issue concerning the presence of an unauthorised and illegal forum on our campuses, reportedly the ‘PSF TISS’. This group has been engaging in activities that obstruct the institute’s functions, defame the institute, demean members of our community, and create divisions among students and faculty. It has been observed that this group is misleading, distracting and misguiding students from their academic pursuit and harmonious life in the campus. (sic)” — Order by the Office of Registrar, Anil Sutar, Tata Institute of Social Sciences, 19th August 2024 (as reported by Hindustan Times )

Such orders have been on the rise all across India’s higher education institutes, a large number of whom – as rightly being pointed out by independent creators like Dhruv Rathee & Ravish Kumar – have been quietly founded by the Tata Group all along, even those that don’t have ‘Tata’ in the name 17 . Certainly, if the higher educational institutes founded by corporations serve as representations of their & their leader’s thoughts, Tata has time and again made clear where it stands, against the left, if not quite all the way on the right 18 .

But institutional ideology & administrative decisions come in handy for little more than speculation regarding their leaders’ philosophies. A much stronger tool for silent diplomacy in modern geopolitics, is trade 19 , and when it comes to issues like the Palestinian Genocide, the Tata Group has taken an extremely explicit political stance with its supply of Range Rovers to the Israeli Military for use in the Occupied West Bank 20 .

In the Murky Middle: Revisionist History & PR

On the one hand, Tata Steel’s MoU with the state of Chattisgarh involved the signing of a Rs. 10,000 cr. contract for tribal land that would be acquired through the mass killing of tribals by government-employed child soldiers 23 , but it was not Ratan Tata who hired them. It was not Ratan Tata who fired the gun. It is not Rata Tata who pushed employees into vats of steel on a semi-regular basis in his factories or gave speeches against unionisation & worker’s rights. In 2015, the BJP government in Chhattisgarh revoked Tata’s licence 24 over the land it stole from Bastar due to its continued delay in building the steel plant that it had all been for. What is the ideology that one should extract here?

It is this necessitated speculation that breeds ambiguity. There is no ‘source’ telling us which of these decisions were his & what his stances were regarding each one, & it is possible there never will be. Tata’s love for dogs & concern for the middle class on the other hand is verifiably his own. In his own voice & word, conveniently amplified by the media, is the image of a man who ‘donated himself out of billionaire lists’ & flew economy by choice. It is no wonder that people from every strata & ideology queued outside his funeral to get one last glimpse of Ratan Tata’s enshrined body; it is the only look at the man they ever got.

Effective Altruism & Funeral Politics: The Ethics of Philanthropy

Ravish Kumar’s 24-minute bulletin in tribute to Ratan Tata highlights his firmly pacifist stance during the 26/11 attacks on the Tata Group-owned Taj Hotel in an atmosphere of rising anti-Pakistan & anti-Muslim sentiment. As Sourya points out in his statement, silence in times of polarisation is in itself a statement of complicity, & Tata’s silence at the time was antagonistic to the Indian right-wing, spearheaded by the Bajrang Dal & RSS – who were later accused of having orchestrated the attacks after the assassination of Hemant Karkare 25 .

One of the main defences being employed by the present press narrative exalting Tata is his notable lack of billionaire status. Times Now, Business Standard, India TV & Firstpost each 26 released an article on 10th October 2024 on how despite the multibillion-dollar empire he built in the time he oversaw the family conglomerate, Ratan Tata never made it to a billionaire’s list.

“How is it possible that someone who has been at the helm of the country’s largest business conglomerate for six decades (sic) is not in the list of the top 10 or top 20 richest individuals in the country? Yet, this is a fact. The reason for this can also be the large-scale philanthropic work done by the Tata family through the Tata Trust. In fact, the Tata family members traditionally hold minimal personal stakes in their own companies. Jamsetji Tata, the founder of the Tata Group, established a guiding principle that much of the profits earned by Tata Sons should be donated to the Tata Trust for philanthropic purposes. The Tata family has been a pioneer in philanthropic work much before people like Bill Gates.” —Arushi Jaiswal, 10th October 2024, India TV, “Ratan Tata, who built a million-dollar empire, never made it to any billionaires list”

‘Effective altruism’ in the name emerged as a fringe neo-philosophical movement in 2009, & has since undergone a dramatic rise & fall in both popularity & credibility after Sam Bankman Fried – one of the movement’s central figures – was accused and later convicted of crypto fraud last year ; but the philosophy itself isn’t exactly new. Its disgraced founder, 28 William McAskill, merely algorithmised & gave a name to what has always been the main tenet of all philanthropic ethic: In direct opposition to the popular proverb from the Hippocratic Oath, the very idea of ‘earning-to-give’ is premised upon first causing harm, then offsetting it via donation. In her video on effective altruism, YouTuber and thespian Abigail Thorn explains this phenomenon:

“Several years ago I was invited to be the ethics consultant at a banking conference. They put me on a business class flight to a luxury hotel in Madrid, [where] over several days, I and the other attendees discussed how we could fix the various problems facing the world: healthcare, debt, financial collapse. [...] Conferences like that are held all the time. At the top end you’ve got stuff like the World Economic Forum, the Clinton Global Initiative and the Social Good Summit; further down the list is the thing that I went to. Rich people have been trying to figure out the most effective way to get rid of their money for a long time.” — Abigail Thorn, 25th February

*Darjeeling. From Kashmir to Manipur and Nagaland, Tata trucks and drones are merely another name for military rule.” — Sourya, General Secretary, COLLECTIVE Delhi*

**Censorship, Palestine, & Institutional ideology**

Readers at this point in the article, have they not been keeping up with the news, may find themselves confused with this statement. After all, when there is genocide – several counts thereof – on one’s resume, what ambiguity can there be?

*2023, The Rich Have Their Own Ethics: Effective Altruism & the Crypto Crash (ft. Finn5ter) , @PhilosophyTube on YouTube*

CONTINUED ON PAGE 6 →



The video goes on to trace the downfall of the effective altruism movement, which by 2015, coming back to Tata, had itself grown into a multibillion dollar project . Finishing her anecdote about the banking conference she was invited to, Thorn says, “[When the last day finally] came, I closed out the conference by giving my keynote speech. And my ethical advice to all these bankers was that they should immediately resign.”

Conclusion

“It is said that one should not criticise a person after their death. Well, even during Ratan Tata’s lifetime, we have spoken ill of him and will continue to do so; a life of luxury and comfort tends to reflect a certain soft sensitivity and generosity on a person’s face. A hungry child, writhing with hunger, may grab his brother’s collar and say, “Give me food, you bastard.” It takes centuries and billions of wealth for newly emerged capitalists, who flee their society after violence, to achieve such an innocent image.” — Sourya, General Secretary, COLLECTIVE Delhi

Funerals, after all, are for the living.

LABOUR

Fickle Grief: COLLECTIVE Delhi Secretary Sourya’s Full Statement Against the Posthumous Veneration of Ratan N. Tata

COLLECTIVE Delhi’s General Secretary Sourya’s full statement on the posthumous veneration of Ratan N. Tata — challenging the media narrative of ethical entrepreneurship with a record of the Tata Group’s land acquisitions, displacement of communities, and the selective memory that public mourning makes both possible and convenient.

BY SOURYA

Following is the full statement by COLLECTIVE Delhi’s General Secretary, Sourya against the largely positive posthumous regard for Tata Group’s late chairman, Ratan N. Tata, that has taken the world & Internet by storm in the wake of his passing on 9th October 2024. The billionaire industrialist, who succumbed to natural causes at the age of 86, has been lauded as a visionary by politicians & public figures both in India & around the world, & these comments have received widespread media coverage over the last 24 hours .

Beyond media coverage, a proposal for awarding Tata a posthumous Bharat Ratna has

Through the hours of 10AM to 4PM today, 10th October 2024, Tata’s body was kept on public display so that the ‘public could pay their respects’, & the same beginning with VIP visits to the body till the last rites conducted with ‘full state honour’ was broadcasted live on national television across news channels. 2 The following testimony heavily criticizes this posthumous veneration of the industry giant by public figures & the media alike , & calls out the hypocrisy of glorifying an individual post their death when that perspective remained absent, or even antagonistic, during their life .

Prior to his death, Tata’s mega-corporation has repeatedly been accused of negligence & hazardous working conditions under his chairmanship, resulting in several employee deaths, & has remained controversial for its close involvement with ruling governments & land acquisition projects. Recently, the Tata Group had also been supplying automobiles to the Israeli military for use in the Occupied West Bank. Read the report here.

After the advent of neoliberalism and the resurgence of capitalism in Soviet Russia and China, many scholars celebrated what they deemed the ‘end of ideologies.’ This was also referred to as “there is no alternative” (TINA). Over the past three decades, multinational companies like Tata and Adani have reached historic heights of dominance, yet the country has seen increases in malnutrition, unemployment, displacement, and communal, casteist, and patriarchal frenzy. According to statistics, today, the level of inequality in the country is greater than during British rule. This is not merely coincidental.

The memorial for 13 martyrs in Kalinga Nagar, Odisha, remains a proud symbol of tribal resistance. These martyrs rose against Tata Steel, wielding bows and arrows to protect their cultural and natural heritage. When the country’s first ‘Special Economic Zone’ was established in Bengal during the CPI (Marxist) regime in 2003, Tata and Indonesia’s Salem Group were its first consumers. In Singur and Nandigram, landless and small farmers were forcibly evicted from their land, and the red flag was crushed by this very government. The Tata Nano plant in Singur, heralded as a model of leftist industrialization, later moved to Sanand, Gujarat. The reality is that thousands of farmers were displaced, providing jobs to only 200 permanent and 1,800 contract workers.

On one hand, to ideologically defend their profit-based system, Tata Steel has established institutions like the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS) and Tata Environment Research Institute (TERI) using their financial clout; on the other hand, to pit the oppressed against each other, private militias like Salwa Judum and Operation Green Hunt have been funded by houses like Tata and Jindal. Beyond Tata, fishermen from Kerala to Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, and Bengal are fighting against Adani Port. There seems to be no alternative to this inhumane model of ‘development’ from either the ruling or opposition parties.

It is said that one should not criticise a person after their death. Well, even during Ratan Tata’s lifetime, we have spoken ill of him and will continue to do so; a life of luxury and comfort tends to reflect a certain soft sensitivity and generosity on a person’s face. A hungry child, writhing with hunger, may grab his brother’s collar and say, "Give me food, you bastard." It takes centuries and billions of wealth for newly emerged capitalists, who flee their society after violence, to achieve such an innocent image.

already been tabled by the Chief Minister of Maharashtra, Eknath Shinde, who has also announced that a 'State funeral' will be organised for him, as reported by mint (sic). This despite the fact that Tata himself was vocally against receiving the Bharat Ratna, & had requested the efforts to award him one to be stopped back in 2021 during a campaign for his nomination for the same. Zee TV founder & billionaire Subhash Chandra Goenka has also announced a biopic. 1

# The Back Page

Sudoku · October 2024

|   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 |   | 2 | 3 | 9 |   |   |   | 4 |
|   |   | 7 |   | 1 |   |   | 5 |   |
|   |   |   |   | 4 | 7 | 8 |   |   |
| 6 | 5 |   | 7 |   |   | 2 | 1 |   |
|   |   |   | 2 | 3 |   | 5 |   | 6 |
|   | 2 |   |   | 6 |   |   | 4 |   |
| 2 | 4 |   | 1 | 5 |   |   | 6 |   |
| 5 |   | 3 | 9 |   |   | 4 | 8 |   |
|   |   |   |   | 2 |   |   | 3 |   |

Fill every row, column and 3×3 box with 1–9.

## Reader-supported journalism



UPI / Paytm (India)



Read online

<https://thevoiceexpress.in>